Reading books and materials for the assessment table

The Early Reading Screen has its own graded passages, so the assessment can run with no books at all. A small set of **real levelled books** is still worth having: some children read more confidently from a real book; the assessor can check a result with an unseen text; and the same books tell the homeroom teacher exactly where to start the child's reading. This list says which books to buy, which titles to use for a running record at each level, and what to use with older students who read at a low level.

Checked October 2026 on Oxford University Press (Oxford Owl, OUP China) and UK school supplier pages. Pack contents and ISBNs change: check the ISBN with the supplier before ordering. ISBNs marked * were seen only in retailer search listings.

1. Levels, bands and ages

Oxford Reading Tree uses **Oxford Levels**; most UK schools also use **book band colours**. The Early Reading Screen passages use the same bands.

Oxford Level	Book band	Oxford's guide age (fluent English readers)	Early Reading Screen passage
1	Lilac (wordless)	3 to 4	
1+	Pink	4 to 5	1
2	Red	4 to 5	2
3	Yellow	4 to 5	3
4	Light Blue	4 to 6	4
5	Green	5 to 6	5
6	Orange	5 to 6	6
7	Turquoise	5 to 6	7
8	Purple (TreeTops: Brown)	6 to 7	7
9	Gold (TreeTops: Brown)	6 to 8	8
10	White (TreeTops: Brown)	6 to 8	8
11	Lime (TreeTops: Brown)	6 to 8	above the screen: use books
12	Lime+ (TreeTops: Grey)	6 to 8	above the screen: use books

Oxford's end-of-year expectations for fluent English readers (a guide only): end of Reception Level 3; end of Year 1 Level 6; end of Year 2 Level 10; end of Year 3 Level 13; end of Year 4 Level 15. So a fluent English reader **starting** Year 1 reads at about Yellow, starting Year 2 at about Orange, and starting Year 3 at about White. Most children joining from Chinese schools read below this at entry. That is expected, and is what the English band (A to E) takes into account.

TreeTops (Oxford Reading Tree for juniors) starts at Level 8, with a band of its own (Brown at Levels 8 to 11, Grey from 12). The books look older while the text stays easy, which suits students in Year 3 and above who read at a low level.

2. What to buy: one set for the assessment table

For each level, buy one fiction pack and one non-fiction pack. **Decode and Develop** and **inFact** are the best choice for running records, because children from bilingual schools have often already read the core Biff, Chip and Kipper "Stories". Before a running record, always ask: "Have you read this book before?" If yes, choose another.

Level	Band	Fiction pack (ISBN)	Non-fiction pack (ISBN)	Suggested running record titles
1+	Pink	Decode and Develop, pack of 6 (9780198483762); Biff, Chip and Kipper First Sentences, pack of 6 (9780198480617)	inFact, mixed pack of 6 (9780198370727)	*The Trampoline* (F); *Hide and Seek* (F); *Legs!* (NF)
2	Red	Decode and Develop (9780198483854); Stories, pack of 6 (9780198481157)	inFact, mixed pack of 6 (9780198370802)	*The Odd Egg* (F); *The Go-Kart* (F); *Pancakes* (NF)
3	Yellow	Decode and Develop (9780198483946); Stories (9780198481690)	Explore with Biff, Chip and Kipper, mixed pack of 6 (9780198396673*); or inFact single titles	*Helicopter Rescue* (F); *A Cat in the Tree* (F); *How We See* (NF, inFact)
4	Light Blue	Decode and Develop (9780198484035); Stories (9780198482055)	Explore, mixed pack of 6 (9780198396758*); or inFact single titles	*The Seal Pup* (F); *The Storm* (F); *Tree Town* (NF, inFact)
5	Green	Decode and Develop (9780198484127); Stories (9780198482413)	Explore, mixed pack of 6 (9780198396833*)	*Rats!* (F); *The Magic Key* (F); *Map, Compass, Explore!* (NF, Explore)
6	Orange	Decode and Develop (9780198300144); Stories (9780198482772)	inFact (9780198307839)	*Two Left Feet* (F); *Kipper and the Giant* (F); *Who Eats Who?* (NF)
7	Turquoise	Decode and Develop (9780198300229); Stories, pack of 6 (9780198483045)	inFact (9780198307846)	*The Time Capsule* (F); *Lost in the Jungle* (F); *Bug Buzz* (NF)
8	Purple	Decode and Develop (9780198300304*); Stories, current mixed pack of 4 (9781382038645)	inFact (9780198307853)	*The Beehive Fence* (F); *The Rainbow Machine* (F); *Beaks and Feet* (NF)
9	Gold	Decode and Develop (9780198300380); Stories, current mixed pack of 5 (9781382038683)	inFact (9780198307860)	*The Journey* (F); *Green Island* (F); *Your Body, Inside Out* (NF)
10	White	Story Sparks, pack of 6 (9780198356653)	inFact (9780198307877)	*Pablo's Travelling Notebook* (F); *The Dinosaur Hunters* (NF)
11	Lime	Story Sparks, Levels 10 to 11, pack of 6 (9780198356738)	inFact, Levels 10 to 11 (9780198307884)	*Do Tigers Have Nine Lives?* (F); *Tasty Travels* (NF)
10 to 12	Brown and Grey	Time Chronicles, 18-book collection (Biff, Chip and Kipper chapter books; 9780192758613)		*The Strange Box* (Level 10); *Time Runners* (Level 11)

Stories with familiar settings. Some titles have Chinese or East Asian settings, which can help a child talk about the story: *The Dragon Dance* (Level 4 More Stories B), *The Magic Paintbrush* (Level 5 Traditional Tales), *The New Year Race* (Level 6 Decode and Develop), *Holiday in Japan* (Level 7 Decode and Develop), *Mulan* (Level 9 Traditional Tales). Familiar content makes comprehension easier, so use them for talk rather than for a first running record.

Do not use these titles, which are in old packs but no longer in the current ones (some were withdrawn by the publisher): *The Hole in the Sand* (Level 2); *Chinese Adventure*, *The Jigsaw Puzzle*, *Australian Adventure* (Level 7); *The Flying Carpet*, *The Kidnappers*, *Egyptian Adventure* (Level 8); *Survival Adventure*, *Rescue!*, *The Blue Eye* (Level 9). Buy the current Level 7 to 9 packs listed above, not older six-book packs.

Old stock. Books labelled "Stage" (rather than "Level"), or with the old names Owls, Magpies or Wrens, come from before 2011. Stages 1 to 9 in the 2011 edition match Levels 1 to 9, but older series names do not. Home editions ("Read with Oxford", Stages 1 to 6) use a different numbering altogether. Level each book from Oxford's reading

record list, not from the cover: Oxford Owl, "Pupil reading record: Oxford Levels 1 to 20" (oxfordowl.co.uk/contents/57667).

3. Phonics-matched books

For a child whose phonics screen shows they are still learning letter sounds and blending, a fully decodable book gives a fairer running record than a story book.

Level	Floppy's Phonics Fiction, pack of 6	Titles to use	Songbirds (Julia Donaldson)
1+	9780198484974	*Cats*; *Pop!*; *Hats*	*Top Cat*; *Sam's Pot* (pack 9780198387909)
2	9780198485063	*The Zip*; *Jack*; *Quiz*	*The Odd Pet*; *Fish and Chips* (pack 9780198388081)
3	9780198485155	*Leek Hotpot*; *Toads in the Road*	*The Big Match*; *The Shopping List* (pack 9780198388265)
4	9780198485247	*The Crab Dragon*; *The Lost Chimp*	*Spike Says*; *Tadpoles*
5	9780198485339	*The Gale*; *Rowing Boats*	*Sue Kangaroo*; *Usman's Books*

If the school teaches phonics with Read Write Inc., use its Book Bag Books instead: Red Ditty, Green and Purple (Set 1 sounds), Pink, Orange and Yellow (Set 2), Blue and Grey (Set 3). For example Purple pack 9780198420088, Pink 9780198420200, Orange 9780198420323.

4. Older students who read at a low level (Years 3 to 10)

Students of 8 to 15 who are new to English should not be asked to read books that look as if they are for infants. Use books that look their age while the text stays simple.

Series	Who it suits	Titles to start with
Oxford Reading Tree TreeTops, Levels 8 to 11 (Brown band)	Years 3 to 6 reading at about Purple to Lime	Greatest Stories, Levels 8 and 9, mixed pack (9780198305743); *Puss in Boots*, *The Magic Cow* (Level 9); *The Pied Piper* (Level 10); *Animal Tricksters* (Level 11)
Collins Big Cat Progress (two bands: reading level, then interest level; "a Key Stage 2 look and feel")	Years 3 to 6 reading at Yellow to Lime	*Mission Mars* (reads Yellow, 9780007428717); *Seal Skull* (Blue, 9780007428830); *Amazing Escapes* (Green, 9780007428915); *Search and Rescue Dogs* (Orange, 9780007498376); *Formula 1* (Turquoise, 9780007498437); *The Terror Birds* (Purple, 9780007498543); *Votes for Women* (Gold, 9780007498611); *Extreme Animals* (White, 9780007519286); *Space Jump* (Lime, 9780007519385)
Reading Planet: Astro (Hachette Learning)	Ages 7 to 11 reading about a year below age	*Planet Protectors*; *Exploring Space*; *When Experiments Go Wrong*; *Your Brilliant Brain* (9781398324350)
Barrington Stoke (each book shows a reading age and an interest age)	Interest age 9+ or 11+, reading age 6 to 7	Interest 9+: *Snow Dogs* (reading age 6, 9781781123799); *Front Foot* (reading age 7, 9780008695712). Interest 11+: *Fit* (reading age 6, 9780008791506); *Protest* (6, 9780008791513); *Life Hack* (7, 9780008800765); *Escape* (7, 9780008758943)
Rapid Plus (Pearson)	Ages 11 to 14, "English language learners and struggling readers", reading ages 6.6 to 9.6	Stage 3A: *Rescue*, *Rivals*; Stage 5A: *Excuses Excuses*; Stage 9.2: *Second Chance*

For a teenager who is completely new to English, the Graded Sentence Reading Screen and the Early Reading Screen's letter sounds and Section 1 words are better than any book: no hi-lo series checked goes below about Yellow band or a reading age of 6.

5. Free and online options

- **Oxford Owl eBook library** (home.oxfordowl.co.uk/books/free-ebooks): free levelled eBooks for ages 3 to 11, including Oxford Reading Tree, Read Write Inc. and Songbirds, searchable by Oxford Level and book band. Free registration is needed. Best on a computer or tablet. Useful for families to read at home at the level the assessment found.
- **Oxford Owl for School**: free teacher registration gives extra eBooks (30 Oxford Primary titles and 50 Read Write Inc. titles) through class logins, plus teaching notes for every pack, and the reading record list of every Oxford Reading Tree title by level.
- Check that these sites load reliably from the school network in China before relying on them on the day.

6. Buying in China

- **Imported Oxford Reading Tree** "校园版" (school edition) sets are sold on JD.com, including some sold by JD itself, and labelled 牛津大学出版社. Check that what arrives matches the pack contents above.
- **Chinese editions**: FLTRP (外研社, the 丽声 brand) publishes phonics and non-fiction series based on Oxford Reading Tree, and The Commercial Press (商务印书馆) publishes 牛津阅读树进阶读物 and TreeTops (树冠英语) sets. These are useful for classrooms but are not the same books as the UK packs, so level them carefully.
- **Familiar books.** Oxford Reading Tree is very popular in China, so children from bilingual schools may already know the Biff, Chip and Kipper stories well. This is another reason to run assessments with Decode and Develop, inFact or Collins Big Cat.
- The OUP China (Hong Kong) online shop delivers only to Hong Kong addresses. UK school suppliers (for example Madeleine Lindley) and international school suppliers ship to schools abroad; order by ISBN.

7. Running a running record with a real book

1. Choose a book at the level the child reached on the Early Reading Screen passages (or one level below to start).
2. Mark a section of about 100 words (Levels 1+ to 4: the whole book, often 30 to 80 words). Count the words.
3. Use the running record codes and the accuracy table on the Early Reading Screen record: 95% or more accuracy is easy (independent), 90 to 94% is right for teaching (instructional), below 90% is too hard.
4. Ask three or four questions: one "find it in the book", one "why do you think", one word meaning, and one "what might happen next" or "what did you think of it".
5. Record the title, level, accuracy and comprehension on the Early Reading Screen record.

8. Materials for the assessment room

For	Item
Every room	Pencils, rubbers, a pencil sharpener, a clock or timer, a plain card for covering text, water, tissues
Years 1 and 2	20 counters (or cubes) for maths; crayons (red, blue, green, yellow at least) for the listening task; paper for drawing during the chat
Years 1 to 3	The laminated Early Reading Screen cards and Sentence Reading card; the levelled books above
Years 3 to 10	A ruler (30 cm, cm and mm)
Years 4 to 10	The laminated Sentence Reading card
Listening tasks	The script in the assessor booklet (read aloud live; no recording is needed)
Parent conversation	A quiet second room; a Chinese-speaking colleague if needed